



GUITARHUB

FIELD GUIDE
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FIND THE REAL PROBLEM

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Deliberate practice, *at the instrument.*

One target you cannot hit yet, a difficulty where you keep missing, and something outside your own ear judging each attempt. Here is how to run that without a teacher in the room.

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Deliberate practice on guitar means working on one thing you cannot yet play, at a difficulty where you keep failing, with something outside your own ear judging each attempt. Playing is what you do with material you already own. Deliberate practice is what you do with material you do not. Both belong in a week at the instrument, but only one of them is built to move what is currently out of reach.

This page is about the part of practice you cannot supply by deciding to: an honest verdict on each attempt when nobody else is listening. The target, the tempo and the order of the session are a separate problem, and [how to practice guitar effectively](#) is the page that solves it. Read that one for the shape of the hour. Read this one for how to tell whether the hour worked.

Playing and practicing feel similar and are not

Sit down with a guitar and the default is playing. Your hands reach for the riff you always open with and the two songs you can get through without thinking. Nothing is wrong with that. It is most of why you own the instrument.

Deliberate practice starts somewhere else. You name a failure, and you name it narrowly. Not "get better at barre chords." The B-flat in the second verse buzzes on the third string every time you arrive from an open G. The second sentence is a target. The first is a mood.

Three questions separate them, and you can answer all three about the hour you just finished:

- What was failing when you sat down, and is it still failing now?
- How many times did you stop mid-phrase because something was wrong?
- Could you have played most of that hour while thinking about something else?

If nothing was failing, if you never stopped, and if your attention was free the whole time, you played. That is a legitimate way to spend an hour. It is just not the hour that moves the thing you are stuck on.

Feedback is the mechanism, not an extra

Repetition on its own does not sort good attempts from bad ones. It installs whatever you actually did, at whatever accuracy you actually did it. If your timing drifted late on every pass through a phrase and nothing told you, you rehearsed the drift. This is how practice can feel diligent and change nothing.

A teacher is, mechanically, a feedback machine: a second set of ears that is not busy playing. You do not have one in the room, so you build that function out of parts you already have.

Record the attempt, then listen to it cold

Your ear while playing is occupied. It is running the next chord change, watching your fretting hand, and quietly forgiving you. Your ear on playback has none of those jobs and is much harder to fool.

Record one take on your phone. Then listen for one thing only: was the timing steady, or was the chord clean, or was the bend in tune. One question per listen. The errors you hear on playback were mostly inaudible to you thirty seconds earlier, and that gap is the entire reason to record.

Let the metronome judge instead of accompany

Most players treat a click as a pacer to follow. Use it as a judge instead. Play the passage and pay attention to where you and the click separate, because that tells you which beat is actually causing the problem. Rushing into a hard bar and dragging out of it is a different diagnosis than being late the whole way through.

A click on every beat hides small drift, since you get corrected four times a bar before the error can accumulate. Move the click to beats two and four, or to beat one only, and the drift becomes obvious. If you cannot hear yourself against it, the click is too quiet or the tempo is too fast.

Use a tool that reports something you cannot hear

Software that listens while you play can flag notes and timing you would argue with on your own. It does not know what you are trying to sound like, so it is not a replacement for your judgment. It is useful for the narrow question of whether what you played matches what you intended. [Strumly's guide to practicing with an AI coach](#) is a longer read on where that fits into a session.

Work at the edge of what you can do

The edge is the level where you fail some of the time, about half the time. Not most of the time, and not never. It is the diagnostic gear: the place you find out what fails. The fix itself gets built one gear down, at the tempo where every attempt is clean.

Far below the edge, on material you already own, you are playing. The attempts come out clean because they were always going to come out clean, and nothing about your playing had to change to produce them.

Above the edge you are generating noise. When every attempt collapses, you cannot tell which one was closer, so there is nothing to correct toward. Practice above the edge feels like hard work and returns almost no information.

The edge has a specific discomfort to it: you can nearly do the thing. You get it, lose it, and get it again. That instability is the point. It means the thing is still being built rather than already built or not yet started.

Finding it is mechanical, and the arithmetic of climbing back up from it belongs to the session rather than to this page: the tempo work is laid out in [how to practice guitar effectively](#). What matters here is that the edge is a place you have to locate by ear before any of it starts, because a tempo you chose for being comfortable is not a tempo that tells you anything.

The edge also moves. A tempo that was hard last week becomes a warm-up, which means practicing at last week's edge is playing. Re-find it every few sessions instead of assuming it stayed put.

It is meant to be short, and it is meant to be uncomfortable

Attention is the constraint here, not time. Deliberate practice asks you to hold a target in mind, notice a specific error, and change something on the next attempt. That kind of attention runs out well before your hands do.

When it runs out, the session does not visibly fall apart. It degrades quietly. You keep repeating the passage, you stop catching the errors, and you start banking attempts at an accuracy you would not have accepted twenty minutes earlier. Stopping is the right move and also the hard one, because the guitar is still in your hands and the room is still quiet.

The discomfort is not a virtue and it is not the goal. It is a location signal. A practice block that is entirely comfortable has drifted below the edge, which means you are playing. A block that is grim start to finish is above it.

Twenty deliberate minutes against two unfocused hours

The difference is not willpower or talent. It is how many attempts got judged.

Two unfocused hours can contain hundreds of repetitions. Most of them are of material you already play, at a tempo you already own, and none of them were checked against anything. The four bars that are actually broken get a handful of passes on the way by, usually inside the whole song, usually at full speed, usually with the same error each time.

Twenty deliberate minutes might contain thirty attempts. Each one is aimed at a single target, at a tempo where the outcome is in doubt, and each one is followed by a decision about what to change.

Here is what those twenty minutes can look like:

1. Two minutes: play the passage once at full speed and record it. That take is your before.
2. Three minutes: listen back and name one error. Not three. One.
3. Ten minutes: find the tempo where that error shows up about half the time and watch what fails. Then drop to the tempo where the fix comes out clean every time, changing one thing per attempt. A fingering, an anchor finger, where the shift starts, where you breathe. Climb back toward the edge as it holds.
4. Three minutes: return to full speed and record the same passage again.
5. Two minutes: write down what changed and what you will start with tomorrow.

The two hours are not wasted. They are how songs get into your hands and how playing stays worth doing. But if a month of them has produced no change in the thing you cannot play, the missing ingredient is the twenty minutes rather than more hours. That is the usual shape of a practice plateau.

What deliberate practice does not mean

- **Not more hours.** It describes what a block of practice contains, not how long you sit with the guitar.
- **Not drills instead of songs.** A song is fine material. The deliberate part is what you do with the four bars of it that keep collapsing.
- **Not a daily obligation.** A short focused block a few times a week is deliberate practice. A daily streak of unfocused repetition is not.
- **Not gear or software dependent.** It needs a target, a tempo you can move, and a way to hear yourself back. A phone covers the third one.
- **Not the whole session.** Fifteen focused minutes followed by an hour of playing is a good session. Ninety minutes of half-attention is one long warm-up.

Where to point it

The method is useless without a target, and picking one is the part most players skip. If you are not sure where to aim, the [practice plateau diagnostic](#) asks the questions that usually surface it. If you already know the target and want the structure that goes around the deliberate block, [how to practice guitar effectively](#) covers the rest of the session, and [Strumly's guide to designing a practice routine](#) covers the weekly shape around that.

Common questions

Is deliberate practice just practicing slowly?

No. Slowing down is one way to reach the edge, and often the right one, but a slow repetition with no target and no feedback is still just a repetition. What matters is whether each attempt is aimed at something specific and checked afterward, not the number on the metronome.

How long should a deliberate practice block be?

Short enough that your attention holds for the whole of it. Twenty minutes on one target is a reasonable place to start, less on a tired day. When you stop hearing your own mistakes, the block is finished, whatever the clock says.

Can you practice deliberately without a teacher?

Yes, but you have to replace what a teacher supplies: a target chosen for you, an honest read on each attempt, and a decision about what to change next. The target and the decision you can supply yourself. The honest read is the part to hand off, to a recording, to a metronome, or to software that listens while you play.

Does this mean playing for fun is a waste of practice

time?

No. Playing is the reason for the practice, and it is how songs settle into your hands. The two just do different jobs, so a week containing only one of them gets only one of the two results.

GuitarHub Field Guide No. 04. The latest version of this guide, with its tools and links, lives at guitarhub.org/deliberate-practice-guitar.

AI Instructions